Foreword to the Rails 8 Edition

I’ve been working on Rails for over twenty years now, and incredibly, this book has been around for almost as long, helping programmers get quickly up to speed on the framework. That kind of dedication doesn’t come around by accident, but from a consistent commitment to teaching programmers how to write beautiful code for the web. That’s what Rails is: a love letter to the web written in Ruby. And this book is here to help you become a coauthor.

In the past two decades, a lot has changed about how we build for the web. When Rails was first created, there were no web sockets, the use of JavaScript was modest (or even optional!), and cloud computing had barely gotten started. But as much as those factors have changed, there are also a lot that haven’t. If you wrote a Rails application ten or even fifteen years ago, you’ll instantly recognize the shape of the new app skeleton that Rails 8 delivers today. You’ll be able to draw on experience working with Active Record and Action Controller because, while both have gotten better, they’re still based on the same fundamentally sound principles.

That’s the long-term magic of Ruby on Rails. The ability to draw a yield from investments made in mastering the basics for years if not decades to come. Making that first deposit towards those investments is what this book is all about. To put a stop to, or at least provide an alternative to, the constant churning and thrashing that has beset the world of web development.